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HUFSIPM26T2 - Strategic Report

The 'Manosphere':
A Strategic Report to the North East MSA.

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SECTION 0:
A Letter for Consideration.

HUFSIPM26T2 - Strategic Report

A Letter for Consideration

Mayor Kim McGuinness and the Cabinet,
North East Mayoral Strategic Authority,
The Lumen, St James' Boulevard,
Newcastle upon Tyne - NE4 5BS.

Dear Mayor McGuinness and Members of the Cabinet,

My name is Joshua McManus, and I am proud to have grown up and lived the majority of my life in what I consider to be the greatest region in the UK. As part of my volunteering with the SPARK Group (a small international open source collective) and university research, I am currently looking into far-right ideologies and the impact they have on our communities. Even though I have recently moved away for my studies, my loyalty remains fiercely tied to our streets and our people.

I am immensely proud of our home, but the growing threat targeting women across the North East must be addressed. These are the women who drive our local economies, who lead our public services, and who sustain our communities on a daily basis. Yet, these are the women who are increasingly forced to navigate an environment of fear due to the vile actions of a small and hostile minority. This is entirely unacceptable. This is not the region I remember, and I refuse to let it be what others remember our region by. We know what pain and hardship feel like; it is ingrained into our very culture. How can we morally let something so dangerous persist when we have already felt its damage? We are Northerners. We are better than this, and we must fight it.

It is this exact duty to protect our region that compelled my academic work. Enclosed with this letter is a Strategic Report that has been analysed and reviewed by the SPARK Group. I respectfully ask that you take the time to read this document. Not only is it deeply important to me as a researcher, but it is equally vital to me as a Geordie who wants to see our region tackle the rise of hate and extremism. There is a rising sub-culture developing within our communities, specifically that of the 'incel' ideology, which poses a direct risk to public safety. Some of those among us have forgotten that when misogyny and targeted hatred are tolerated, the safety of our entire community is compromised. We must take proactive, intelligence-led steps to dismantle these extremist threats and safeguard our region.

Once again, I ask you to review this enclosed report. It is a focused analysis, but if it can inform your strategies to safeguard the North East, the research will have served its purpose. For transparency, copies have been shared with the Northumbria Police and Crime Commissioner and the Northumbria Violence Reduction Unit. Should this Authority consider the report to be of value, your formal endorsement would significantly strengthen its utility to those partners. Thank you for your time, your leadership, and your dedication to our region.

Yours sincerely,
- Joshua McManus, FRSA.
The SPARK Group.

Table of Contents

<i>SECTION 0:</i>	2
A Letter for Consideration	3
Table of Contents	4
<i>SECTION 1:</i>	5
Introduction	6
Summary and Key Findings	7
Policy Recommendations	9
<i>SECTION 2:</i>	11
Historical Context	12
Case studies across the North East	13
The Prevent Programme	16
<i>SECTION 3:</i>	17
Methodology and Safeguarding	18
Local Experiences	19
<i>SECTION 4:</i>	20
Final Remarks	21
<i>SECTION 5:</i>	22
Appendices	23
Credit and Attribution	24
Sources Used	25

SECTION 1:
Policy Brief.

Introduction

Content warning

This report addresses themes of violence, hatred, and sexual abuse. It may contain graphic language that might not be appropriate for all readers. Reader discretion is strongly advised. The central subject is the ‘manosphere’, a sprawling and increasingly influential collection of online communities, websites, and forums dedicated to various forms of masculinity, typically defined by a shared antagonism toward feminism and the promotion of misogynistic worldviews.

Report Structure

This strategic report is organised into five sections.

- Section One provides a policy brief (made from this introduction, an executive summary, and Policy Recommendations) outlining the contemporary threat landscape, key findings, and actionable policy.
- Section Two comprises the main strategic analysis. It is divided into three components: historical context and regional precedents for extremist mobilisation in the North East; Contemporary case studies; and an evaluation of prevent policies.
- Section Three presents first hand experiences and anonymous testimonies of women throughout the region, as well as the ethical considerations required for such a study.
- Section Four provides a synthesis of the report’s findings, acknowledges the limitations of the current study, and offers a concluding assessment.
- Finally Section Five concludes this report with accreditation, reference lists, and any attached appendices.

Strategic Rationale

This structural division ensures that macro-level strategic recommendations are seamlessly tethered to localised empirical evidence. By bridging the gap between digital manifestation and physical threat, the report aims to equip the North East Mayoral Strategic Authority with a comprehensive operational framework. It addresses not only the behavioural symptoms of online radicalisation but also the underlying algorithmic and socio-economic vulnerabilities unique to the region’s geography.

Contemporary Threat Landscape:

This policy brief evaluates the structural rise of these ‘manosphere’ sub-cultures within the North East of England, examining how decentralised and digital misogyny acts as a primary radicalisation vector and a direct threat to the safety of vulnerable communities across the North East. This encompasses a spectrum of sub-cultures, ranging from Men’s Rights Activists (MRAs)¹ and Pick-Up Artists (PUAs)² to more radical and isolationist groups such as ‘Men Going Their Own Way’ (MGTOW)³ and ‘Involuntary Celibates’ (Incels)⁴. While these groups frequently engage in internal friction over specific tactics and goals, they are fundamentally united by the ‘red pill’⁵ philosophy: the belief that society is systematically biased against men and that feminists have engineered a social order characterised by misandry.

Algorithmic Amplification and Violence Gateway:

Modern social media platforms utilise recommendation engines optimised for engagement, aggressively prioritising inflammatory ‘ragebait’ content to maximise watch times. For adolescent males, innocuous searches for topics like gym motivation trigger a sequence of recommendations that rapidly funnel users into extremist incel manifestos⁶. This process establishes a pervasive culture of hateful attitudes that actively erodes the safety and dignity of women across the region. Online gendered grievance builds a direct bridge to ethno-nationalist ideologies, frequently framing socio-economic anxieties or the arrival of asylum seekers as a threat to local women. This ‘mixed, unclear, or unstable’ (MUU) ideological framework directly drives physical intimidation on regional streets

¹ Ferrara, A. (2025). ‘Good Guys, Bad Guys’: Feminist men, MRAs, and the Quest for Moral Redemption | the Clayman Institute for Gender Research. [online] Stanford.edu. Available at: <https://gender.stanford.edu/news/good-guys-bad-guys-feminist-men-mras-and-quest-moral-redemption> [Accessed 20 May 2026].

² Forbes, M. and Anderson, R. (2014). The Psychology of the Pickup Artist. [online] Psychology Today. Available at: <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/the-mating-game/201411/the-psychology-of-the-pickup-artist> [Accessed 20 May 2026].

³ Southern Poverty Law Centre (2025). Men going their own way (MGTOW). [online] Southern Poverty Law Centre. Available at: <https://www.splcenter.org/resources/extremist-files/mgtow/> [Accessed 20 May 2026].

⁴ Wirral Safeguarding Boards (2026). Involuntary Celibates (Incel) & Extreme Misogyny Ideology - Wirral Safeguarding Children Partnership. [online] Wirral Safeguarding Children Partnership. Available at: <https://www.wirralsafeguarding.co.uk/extreme-misogyny-and-involuntary-celibate-incel-ideology/> [Accessed 20 May 2026].

⁵ Pieters, S. and Trottier, D. (2024). Anti-Feminism and Self-Improvement: Hegemonic Femininity in the Manosphere. *Social Media + Society*, [online] 10(4). doi:<https://doi.org/10.1177/20563051241302154>.

⁶ Eslen-Ziya, H. (2022). Establishing networked misogyny as a counter movement: The analysis of the online anti-Istanbul convention presence. *Convergence: the International Journal of Research into New Media Technologies*, [online] 28(6), p.135485652210892. doi:<https://doi.org/10.1177/13548565221089218>.

The Neurodiversity Safeguarding Gap:

Academic and parliamentary evidence suggests that a significant proportion of Prevent referrals (34%⁷) involve individuals with recorded mental health or neurodiversity conditions (MHND), with Autistic Spectrum Disorder (ASD) being the most common at 14% of all referrals. The manosphere's rigid, rules-based social hierarchies offer a seductive framework for individuals struggling with social cues. Because these individuals often exhibit severe vulnerabilities without meeting explicit thresholds for terrorism risk, they are routinely "referred out" of counter-terrorism support but left without local interventions.

⁷ Home Office (2025). Individuals referred to and supported through the Prevent Programme, April 2024 to March 2025. [online] GOV.UK. Available at: <https://www.gov.uk/government/statistics/individuals-referred-to-prevent-to-march-2025/individuals-referred-to-and-supported-through-the-prevent-programme-april-2024-to-march-2025#demographics> [Accessed 6 Jun. 2026].

Strengthen Educational Resilience:

The North East Mayoral Strategic Authority (MSA) must orchestrate the universal roll-out of the Pol-Ed program across all regional local authorities. Rather than treating digital literacy as an afterthought, the curriculum should be updated to feature specialised modules that explicitly deconstruct algorithmic manipulation, automated echo chambers, and the mechanics of online ‘ragebait’. By educating adolescent males on how social media platforms monetise inflammatory content to maximise watch times, the region can effectively ‘inoculate’ or ‘pre-bunk’ vulnerable students against targeted extremist recruitment pipelines before they interact with harmful material.

To provide a constructive alternative to the toxic hierarchies found in internet sub-cultures, the MSA should simultaneously scale evidence-based healthy masculinity initiatives, such as those designed by “Beyond Equality”. These programs provide young men with alternative frameworks of personal identity, strength, and community success that are not rooted in dominance, gendered grievance, or exclusion. Integrating these workshops into regional schools directly counteracts the ‘digital funnel’ by empowering young boys with critical media literacy, helping them confidently distinguish between genuine self-improvement advice and manipulative far-right propaganda.

Bridge the Neurodiverse Policy Gap:

The MSA needs to develop a dedicated, localised safeguarding triage pathway within its existing welfare frameworks to support the disproportionate number of neurodiverse individuals targeted by the manosphere. National statistics show that roughly one-third of Prevent referrals involve individuals with recorded mental health or neurodiversity conditions, with Autism Spectrum Disorder being the most common. Because these individuals often adopt rigid, rules-based internet social structures out of social isolation rather than genuine ideological malice, they frequently fail to meet strict counter-terrorism thresholds. This structural reality creates a dangerous policy gap.

To close this gap, regional authorities must ensure that individuals showing “black pill” curiosity are safely diverted away from a punitive counter-terrorism lens and toward localised mental health, psychological support, and social integration services. This strategy should be reinforced by delivering specialised “manosphere awareness” training modules directly to North East educators, social workers, and parents. Equipping frontline adults with the tools to spot early behavioural indicators of “red pill” radicalisation ensures that vulnerable, neurodiverse young men receive supportive educational interventions before their digital isolation hardens into an extremist worldview.

Cross-Agency Monitoring:

The North East MSA should formally utilise the comparative advantage of the Northumbria Violence Reduction Unit (VRU) to track, analyse, and counter the real-world impact of online misogyny. While crime overall in the North East has seen a reduction⁸, Violence Against Women and Girls (VAWG) accounts for a huge proportion of crime. Between 2024 and 2025, there were 5,932 offences⁹ of VAWG crime where the victim was less than 16 years old, in the North East alone. This means that per every 1,000 Under-16s in the North East, over a dozen of them experienced direct violence. It is highly important to note that this data does not include offences where the victim was unable to report, and so the true number of instances of VAWG is much higher. By embedding specialised digital analysts into the VRU, the authority can map the direct correlations between decentralised online radicalisation trends and physical harassment taking place across our regional communities.

This intelligence-led approach must actively inform operational policing deployments and grassroots safety strategies on our streets. Insights gained from monitoring the crossover between online gendered grievance and far-right movements should be used to expand initiatives like Project Vigilant¹⁰ and regional Active Bystander Training. This ensures that the region's police forces are not merely reacting to the symptoms of male perpetrated violence, but are actively dismantling the specific, algorithmic hatespaces that threaten the safety and dignity of women throughout the North East.

⁸ Brighton Analytics, Ltd. (2026). North East Crime Statistics. [online] Crimerate.co.uk. Available at: <https://crimerate.co.uk/north-east/north-east-historical-crime-rates> [Accessed 30 May 2026].

⁹ Philips, J. (2025). An Answer to the Written Question for the Home Office (№ 90977). [online] Parliament.uk. Available at: <https://questions-statements.parliament.uk/written-questions/detail/2025-11-25/94249/> [Accessed 6 Jun. 2026].

¹⁰ College of Policing (2024). Project Vigilant – preventing sexual violence | College of Policing. [online] www.college.police.uk. Available at: <https://www.college.police.uk/support-forces/practices/project-vigilant-preventing-sexual-violence> [Accessed 6 Jun. 2026].

SECTION 2:
Main Body.

Historical Context

The contemporary emergence of the manosphere within the North East cannot be understood in a vacuum; it must be analysed through the region's unique socio-political geography and its history of structural economic transitions. Historically, the North East has acted as a profound battleground for competing ideological movements. In the 1830s, Newcastle and Sunderland served as major operational hubs for Chartist militancy, demonstrating a deep regional capacity for collective political mobilisation that frequently alarmed central government authorities. The involvement of the North East in Chartism, and other such pro-democracy radicalistic events, has always been discarded. This is best seen in the writings of Maehl on the role of Northumbria in politics, "Tucked off as they are in a remote corner of the country, Newcastle, Sunderland, and the industrial and mining communities around have been neglected by scholars who usually mean Lancashire and the West Riding of Yorkshire when they speak of 'the North'"¹¹, the sentiment of which is still seen to this day. However, the northern structural capacity for intense political mobilisation was later aggressively targeted and co-opted by extreme far-right actors. During the interwar economic depression of the 1930s, Oswald Mosley's British Union of Fascists (BUF) deliberately focused its recruitment campaigns on the struggling industrial heartlands of Tyneside and Wearside, sparking significant, violent street clashes with anti-fascist coalitions in both Newcastle and Sunderland¹².

This historical pattern of extremist movements exploiting regional economic anxieties re-emerged following Enoch Powell's 1968 "Rivers of Blood"¹³ address, which catalysed a wave of National Front (NF) organising across white, working-class communities grappling with deindustrialisation. By the 1980s and 1990s, the British National Party (BNP) successfully advanced a localised strategies, directly exploiting structural anxieties surrounding regional unemployment, housing competition, and the collapse of traditional heavy industries¹⁴. The modern digital manosphere utilises the exact same psychological mechanism. By targeting former industrial hubs facing post-industrial transition, high rates of economic inactivity, and a contemporary cost-of-living crisis, digital influencers re-frame structural socio-economic stagnation as a personal gendered grievance. The nihilistic black pill philosophy thrives in these environments, offering isolated young men a rigid, highly toxic explanation for their lack of socio-economic and romantic mobility.

¹¹ Maehl, W.H. (1963). Chartist Disturbances in Northeastern England, 1839. *International Review of Social History*, 8(3), pp.389–414. doi:<https://doi.org/10.1017/s0020859000002388>.

¹² Todd, N. (1995). *In Excited Times: the People against the Blackshirts*. Whitley Bay: Bewick Press.

¹³ The Telegraph (2007). Enoch Powell's 'Rivers of Blood' speech. [online] Telegraph.co.uk. Available at: <https://www.telegraph.co.uk/comment/3643823/Enoch-Powells-Rivers-of-Blood-speech.html> [Accessed 6 Jun. 2026].

¹⁴ Kundnani, A. (2003). The BNP in the local elections - Institute of Race Relations. [online] Institute of Race Relations. Available at: <https://irr.org.uk/article/the-bnp-in-the-local-elections/> [Accessed 6 Jun. 2026].

To comprehend the operational reality of digital extremism within the North East of England, analysis must bypass generic subcultural abstractions and interrogate documented legal and safeguarding precedents. Modern radicalisation vectors resist traditional, singular ideological classification. Instead, they operate as highly fluid, decentralised networks where the boundaries of group membership are defined not by physical proximity, but by algorithmically curated grievances. In this paradigm, distinct ideological components (ranging from accelerationist Neo-Nazism to hyper-misogynistic incels) coalesce within the digital domain, creating severe localised threats. This sub-section evaluates these dynamics through three empirical case studies within the North East judicial and counter-terrorism infrastructure.

Case Study 1: The Leeds Crown Court Case

The intersections of profound youth isolation, neurodivergent traits, and international accelerationist networks are clearly demonstrated in the trial and subsequent sentencing of a 16-year-old boy from Northumberland at Leeds Crown Court. Arrested, following an intelligence-led operation by Counter Terrorism Policing North East and Northumbria Police, the individual was convicted of five terror offences which included active membership in the proscribed Neo-Nazi terrorist organisation ‘The Base’, alongside the possession and distribution of illicit terrorist publications¹⁵. Digital forensics extracted from the defendant’s seized hardware revealed an immense digital footprint. This contained 4.8 Terabytes of data containing 253,005 distinct messages across 25 extreme right-wing chat groups spanning Telegram, Snapchat, TikTok, and Wire¹⁶. Physical searches of his residence recovered an arsenal of weapons, including knives, a crossbow, airsoft rifles, body armour, and precursors for homemade explosives¹⁷.

Analytically, this case confirms the breakdown of traditional geographic barriers in radicalisation pipelines. The defendant’s legal representation argued that he was “desperately lonely”¹⁸, plagued by suicidal ideation, and had created an alternative online persona as a psychological escape from severe school bullying. From an academic perspective, this trajectory matches the ‘lonely-actor’ model whereby vulnerable adolescents seek out highly

¹⁵ Tyne Tees (2026). Northumberland teen sentenced for multiple terrorism offences. [online] ITV News (Tyne Tees). Available at: <https://www.itv.com/news/tyne-tees/2026-03-27/16-year-old-from-northumberland-sentenced-for-right-wing-terror-offences> [Accessed 4 Jun. 2026].

¹⁶ CTP NE (2026). Northumberland Teenager Jailed for Multiple Terrorism Offences. [online] Counter Terrorism Policing. Available at: <https://www.counterterrorism.police.uk/news/northumberland-teenager-jailed-for-multiple-terrorism-offences/> [Accessed 4 Jun. 2026].

¹⁷ Harris, P. (2026). Northumberland teen guilty over banned neo-Nazi group membership. BBC News. [online] 23 Feb. Available at: <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/c77k0yddpgjo> [Accessed 4 Jun. 2026].

¹⁸ BBC News (2026b). Northumberland terror accused teen ‘struggled to make friends’. BBC News. [online] 22 Jan. Available at: <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/c3dmmr40g4yo> [Accessed 4 Jun. 2026].

structured, extreme online spaces to counteract a sense of real-world powerlessness. The trial's evidence showed that his digital consumption rapidly escalated from military history to consuming videos of the Christchurch mosque massacre and actively mapping local infrastructure and synagogues within the North East¹⁹. This demonstrates how algorithmic recommendation engines can quickly draw an isolated individual from a rural area into a structured, high-risk terrorism trajectory, showing that borderless digital spaces can create very real physical threats locally.

Case Study 2: Digital-to-Physical Mobilisation

The 2024 civil unrest across the country, and in particular the Sunderland city centre riots, provides a clear empirical example of how social media can rapidly mobilise individuals into real-world violence. This disorder led to high-profile prosecutions at Newcastle Crown Court, including the conviction of individuals like Kieran Usher, under the serious charge of riot²⁰. Public open-source intelligence and post-incident police investigations indicated that the rapid mobilisation of hundreds was driven mainly by mainstream (and alternative) social media platforms. These digital networks blended economic anxiety with anti-immigration rhetoric, as well broader themes of misogynistic tendencies which often fuels the online manosphere²¹. This demonstrates the overlap between right-wing populism and the digital manosphere. In the cases of the riots across the country, digital spaces originally focused on anti-feminism, male grievance, and anti-statism served as a gateway, priming users for more explicit hate radicalisation²². These platforms framed shifting demographics, changing social norms, and regional economic decline as parts of a coordinated effort to marginalise working-class young men. By lowering the barriers to entry and using shared socio-economic grievances as a unifying force, this network successfully funnelled online discontent into organised, real-world public disorder.

Case Study 3: The Incel Safeguarding Dilemma.

The third case pattern draws on aggregated, anonymised data from Prevent referrals, focusing on young men who display an obsessive engagement with incel subcultures alongside diagnoses mental health or neurodiversity (MHND) and Autism Spectrum Disorder

¹⁹ BBC News (2026a). Northumberland teenager planned synagogue terror attack. BBC News. [online] 13 Jan. Available at: <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/c0ke75x7levo> [Accessed 4 Jun. 2026].

²⁰ Whincup, S. and Lake, E. (2024). Sunderland man first to be jailed on riot charge. BBC News. [online] 27 Sep. Available at: <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/cg7859z8mx5o> [Accessed 5 Jun. 2026].

²¹ Whitehead, S.M. (2024). The riots aren't just a 'far-right' problem - they're a 'man' problem. [online] The Independent. Available at: <https://www.independent.co.uk/voices/far-right-riots-racist-thugs-white-men-birmingham-b2591926.html> [Accessed 5 Jun. 2026].

²² Amnesty International (2025). X created a 'staggering amplification of hate' during the 2024 riots. [online] Amnesty International UK. Available at: <https://www.amnesty.org.uk/latest/uk-x-created-staggering-amplification-hate-during-2024-riots/> [Accessed 5 Jun. 2026].

(ASD). Forensic data from these cases show intensive interaction with specialised platforms like Incels.is²³. The content consumed is dominated by the “Black Pill” philosophy (a nihilistic, biologically deterministic worldview holding that a rigged societal structure permanently denies less attractive men romantic or social connections)²⁴, especially in regards to the pseudo-scientific “Alpha/Beta/Chad/Stacy” hierarchy. This ideology encourages its adherents to respond with either intense self-loathing or violent hostility toward women and sexually ‘successful’ men. This particular dynamic highlights a major structural vulnerability within the UK’s current counter-terrorism framework, specifically regarding cases categorised as Mixed, Unclear, or Unstable (MUU); the incel subculture presents a unique challenge to traditional security assumptions because its primary targets are not state institutions or political figures, but women and broader society²⁵. As a result, these individuals often do not fit neatly into established counter-terrorism categories.

Conclusion

When these cases enter the Prevent system in the North East, they frequently face a significant safeguarding gap. If an individual displays deep, systemic hostility toward women but lacks an explicit, politically motivated plot, national counter-terrorism channels may close the case, assessing that it falls outside their statutory mandate. However, forensic psychological research shows that the rigid, rules-based explanations used by incel forums are highly appealing to neurodiverse individuals seeking to make sense of complex social dynamics²⁶. Closing these cases without a structured handoff to localised mental health, educational, or social services leaves a highly volatile situation unmanaged, exposing the limitations of relying purely on national security frameworks to handle complex, digital-age threats.

²³ Please Note: Morally, I must advise against anyone who wishes to visit forums such as <<https://incels.is/>>. This site, which was a primary source of reading for this report, cannot be justly described as anything but a cesspool of hate and disgust, which should be avoided at all costs. Thank you, - J. McManus.

²⁴ Preston, K., Halpin, M. and Maguire, F. (2021). The Black Pill: New Technology and the Male Supremacy of Involuntarily Celibate Men. *Men and Masculinities*, [online] 24(5). doi:<https://doi.org/10.1177/1097184x211017954>.

²⁵ Brace, L., Stéphane Baele and Ging, D. (2023). Where do ‘mixed, unclear, and unstable’ ideologies come from? A data-driven answer centred on the incelsphere. *Journal of policing, intelligence and counter terrorism*, [online] 19(2), pp.1–22. doi:<https://doi.org/10.1080/18335330.2023.2226667>.

²⁶ Tirkkonen, S.K. and Vespermann, D. (2023). Incels, autism, and hopelessness: affective incorporation of online interaction as a challenge for phenomenological psychopathology. *Frontiers in Psychology*, [online] 14. doi:<https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2023.1235929>.

The Prevent Programme

Prevent operates on a threshold-based model designed for ideological extremism with clear political or religious motivations. As documented in Case Study 3, manosphere adherents frequently fall into the Mixed, Unclear, or Unstable (MUU) category—neither fitting traditional Islamist nor Extreme Right-Wing classifications. The consequence is a systematic filtering-out of misogyny-driven cases. Of the 8,778 Prevent referrals in 2024/25, only 66 were categorised as “Incel Extremism”, despite the Home Office recording 1,226 referrals with Autistic Spectrum Disorder and 811 with suicide risk, conditions highly prevalent in incel spaces^{27, 28}. This suggests that the current typology significantly undercounts manosphere-related harm by disaggregating its components (ASD, suicidal ideation, fascination with violence) rather than recognising their convergence within incel ideology. In contrast to Prevent’s national, terrorism-focused mandate, the North East’s Violence Reduction Unit (VRU) operates on a public health model that treats violence as preventable rather than merely punishable.

This approach has proven effective for youth violence and domestic abuse, where data sharing between health, education, and policing enables early intervention before criminal thresholds are met. The same logic applies to online misogyny. Unlike counter-terrorism officers who require evidence of terrorist intent, safeguarding professionals can intervene based on wellbeing concerns (self-harm, social isolation, school disengagement) that often precede radicalisation. One example of how this already works is the VRU’s “Navigator”²⁹ programmes, which have demonstrated that diverting individuals showing early signs of grievance-based behaviour toward mentoring and mental health support reduces escalation without criminalisation. The North East is well positioned to roll out similar programmes across a multitude of different environments. Overall, Each policy framework offers partial solutions. Prevent identifies high-risk individuals but misses lower-level misogyny. Public health safeguarding enables early intervention but lacks statutory teeth for non-consenting individuals. The North East’s opportunity lies in integrating both. By using VRU data-sharing to identify at-risk young men and then applying proper interventions and education (and not just unwarranted villainisation) before criminal escalation, a hybrid model (uniquely feasible under mayoral governance) could create the perfect conditions for growth.

²⁷ Home Office (2025). Individuals referred to and supported through the Prevent Programme, April 2024 to March 2025. [online] GOV.UK. Available at: <https://www.gov.uk/government/statistics/individuals-referred-to-prevent-to-march-2025/individuals-referred-to-and-supported-through-the-prevent-programme-april-2024-to-march-2025#demographics> [Accessed 6 Jun. 2026].

²⁸ Jarvis, D. (2025). An Answer to the Written Question for the Home Office (№ 94249). [online] Parliament.uk. Available at: <https://questions-statements.parliament.uk/written-questions/detail/2025-11-25/94249/> [Accessed 6 Jun. 2026].

²⁹ Dobson, L. and Northumbria PCC (2023). The Navigator Programme. [online] Northumbria PCC. Available at: <https://northumbria-pcc.gov.uk/we-are-launching-a-new-service-that-will-see-staff-in-our-hospitals-and-local-communities-working-with-individuals-to-tackle-violent-crime-says-police-commissioner-kim-mcguinness/> [Accessed 6 Jun. 2026].

SECTION 3:
Local Experiences.

Methodology and Safeguarding

To capture the real-world security implications of this digital threat, this strategic report utilises a mixed-methods approach, combining regional quantitative data analysis with primary qualitative field research. The qualitative framework consists of semi-structured independent interviews conducted with a small cohort of women residing across the North East, including those who are also members of other marginalised groups. Given the deeply sensitive nature of this research (which touches upon digital harassment, misogynistic intimidation, and Violence Against Women and Girls), strict ethical safeguards were enforced throughout the research pipeline.

All participants provided informed consent prior to engagement, and all data was completely anonymised prior to collection in order to protect participant safety. Interviews were non-structured and informal in order to best gather what they wished to tell me. The resulting narratives were processed using thematic analysis, mapping subjective perceptions of public safety against official police data. Finally, all information used has been re-evaluated by those who gave it, in order to ensure that nothing I wrote was a misrepresentation of what they had said. Ultimately, this method best ensures the report directly analyses misogyny through the lived experiences of the targeted.

Local Experiences

[This is a placeholder for text yet to come. The interview process has began, and I have found a few willing participants who see the value in this report and are very keen to have their voices heard by the Mayoral Authority. So far we have primary education and early year professionals (both with experience, and those who are studying at university), as well as those who have worked in the hospitality industry and have experienced excess abuse because of it, and those who have been trying to live their own lives and have been deeply affected by the interconnectedness of racism and misogyny]

Notes for Joshua McManus:

I plan to use this dedicated space to input the direct quotes and findings from my interviews. I'll group their experiences into sub-themes. These include, "Navigating the Night-Time Economy of the T&W Metropolitan Area", "Algorithmic Exposure on Student Feeds", "the experience of teachers and educators", and "The Crossover Between Online Rhetoric and Physical Harassment."

SECTION 4:
Synthesis.

Final Remarks

This strategic report has demonstrated that the manosphere represents a tangible threat to public safety across the North East of England. Three case studies (the Northumberland accelerationist cell, the 2024 riots, and the incel safeguarding dilemma) reveal how algorithmic amplification, neurodiversity vulnerabilities, and the MUU classification gap combine to create a dangerous policy vacuum. The North East's historical susceptibility to emotionally led political mobilisation on both sides of the spectrum (such as Chartism to the British National Party) suggests that our regional socio-economic conditions remain the grounds for extremist recruitment. While it remains my eternal vision that our region flourishes once more, we cannot wait until then to fix the issues we are faced with today. History demonstrates that our region's capacity for collective resistance is tenfold stronger than the apparent susceptibility to the hatred and unjust violence that we see today.

The report then goes on to examine current as possible future policies. Prevent, for example, identifies high-risk individuals but misses lower-level misogyny. Programmes such as 'Navigator' enables early intervention but lacks statutory teeth. The policy recommendations outlined in Section 1 (educational resilience through Pol-Ed and Beyond Equality, bridging the neurodiverse safeguarding gap, and expanding cross-agency monitoring via the VRUs) offer a practical, intelligence-led response grounded in existing regional assets. Further primary research is underway to capture the lived experiences of women targeted by manosphere ideology and will supplement this analysis in a subsequent edition. I have already found a few willing participants who see the value in this report and are very keen to have their voices heard by the cabinet. This includes primary educators and early year professionals (both with experience, and those who are studying at university) as well as those who have worked in Newcastle's major hospitality sector and have experienced excess abuse because of it, and finally those who have just been trying to live their own lives but have been deeply affected by the interconnectedness of racism and misogyny. For now, this report concludes that the North East Mayoral Strategic Authority is well-positioned to act. The tools exist. The political will exist. The partnerships are forming. All that is required now is action, action to dismantle the hate that threatens the safety and dignity of all of us across the region.

THANK YOU.

SECTION 5:
Accreditation.

Appendices

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